

The formulas most office workers actually use, explained simply — with the syntax, what it does, and a working example.

Basic Math & Counting

Formula	What it does	Example
=SUM(range)	Adds up a range of numbers.	=SUM(A2:A10)
=AVERAGE(range)	Finds the average of a range.	=AVERAGE(B2:B20)
=COUNT(range)	Counts cells containing numbers.	=COUNT(C2:C50)
=COUNTA(range)	Counts cells that are not empty (numbers or text).	=COUNTA(D2:D50)
=MAX(range)	Finds the largest value.	=MAX(A2:A10)
=MIN(range)	Finds the smallest value.	=MIN(A2:A10)
=ROUND(num, digits)	Rounds a number to a set number of decimals.	=ROUND(A2, 2)

Conditional Formulas

Formula	What it does	Example
=IF(test, true, false)	Returns one value if true, another if false.	=IF(A2>50,"Pass","Fail")
=SUMIF(range, criteria, sum_range)	Adds values that meet one condition.	=SUMIF(B:B,"Sales",C:C)
=COUNTIF(range, criteria)	Counts cells that meet one condition.	=COUNTIF(A:A,"Completed")
=IFERROR(formula, value_if_error)	Shows a custom message instead of an error.	=IFERROR(A2/B2,"N/A")

Looking Up Data

Formula	What it does	Example
=VLOOKUP(value, table, col_index, FALSE)	Looks up a value in the first column of a table and returns a matching value.	=VLOOKUP(A2,Sheet2!A:D,3,FALSE)

Formula	What it does	Example
=INDEX(range, row_num)	Returns the value at a given position in a range.	=INDEX(A2:A20,5)
=MATCH(value, range, 0)	Finds the position of a value in a range.	=MATCH("John",A2:A20,0)

Text & Dates

Formula	What it does	Example
=CONCATENATE(a, b) or a&b	Joins text from different cells.	=A2&" "&B2
=TEXT(value, format)	Formats a number or date as text.	=TEXT(A2,"dd-mmm-yyy y")
=TODAY()	Inserts today's date, updates automatically.	=TODAY()
=UPPER(text) / =LOWER(text)	Converts text to upper or lower case.	=UPPER(A2)
=TRIM(text)	Removes extra spaces from text.	=TRIM(A2)

Quick Tips

- Start every formula with an equals sign (=).
- Use F4 while typing a cell reference to lock it (e.g. \$A\$2) before copying a formula.
- Press Ctrl + ` (backtick) to see all formulas in a sheet instead of their results.
- If a formula shows #REF!, a cell it depended on was deleted or moved.

These are exactly the kind of formulas covered hands-on in our Professional Computer Basics Course — alongside Word, PowerPoint and Canva.